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The Wodaabe flight

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Section Title(S)

Genealogical Distance and Perceptions of Hierarchy

Genealogical Distance and Perceptions of Hierarchy

In their wet-season gatherings (*worso*), the Wodaabe celebrate both an internal hierarchy and their ethnic "purity", expressed in the ideal of *Pulaaku*, "the Fulani way". What is crucial about this moral code of pastoral Fulani? In Stenning's words, "a man who flouted the code of *pulaaku* was regarded by Wodaabe as mad, since he denied himself the material and moral benefits of living with his clansmen". Following *Pulaaku* thus indicates reason and sanity. These again are almost coterminous with the possession of cattle: when the cattle are lost, their owner loses these qualities (ibid. 59). One can also say that membership in the migratory group is to have rights in its herds.

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Both Dupire and Stenning emphasize the closed, endogamous character of the "clans" or "migratory groups" of the pastoral Wodaabe. Although these communities consist of genealogically heterogeneous elements (families who have joined the following of a prominent headman, dissident groups from other similar communities), their members think about themselves as of common ancestry, and even families, which joined the "clan" relatively recently, count among their fathers the most famous headmen of the group.

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It goes without saying that in these in-marrying communities, agnatic descent lines are confused to an extent which would render hopeless any attempt to treat them as "corporate segments". It might be better to speak about "consubstantiality", which is not only about relations of patri- and matrilineal descent but has the metaphoric dimension of sharing in the cattle herds of the group.

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Writing about the pastoral Fulani of the Adamawa Plateau in Cameroun, Rene Dognin observes that for them cattle is the sign of *barka*, a spiritual quality of successful and leading characters, which in communities of Muslim Fulani is associated with descent from the Prophet. Among pastoral Fulani, *barka* is manifested by the ability to transmit plenty of cattle, wisdom and experience to one's descendants. Founders of migratory communities are assumed to have most *barka*. Since *barka* itself is transmitted from parents to children, the effort to preserve it imposes on the Fulani a norm of endogamy. One could say that *barka* is manifested in the self-sufficiency, integrity and the particular character of the group, above all in the kind of cattle it has. Through selective breeding practices, the cattle of a certain pastoral group acquires in a relatively short time such uniform qualities (patterns of colour, form of horns, stature etc.) as are valued by the herders (Dognin 1975, 299–302).

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In order to understand the ritual-political relations within a nomadic community, we also have to take into account two different notions of hierarchy, both of which articulate relations of power and leadership. On the one hand, agnatic lineages are placed in an order of seniority, which partly displays the difference between the "founders" of the group and more recent arrivals; on the other hand, two lineages allied through cross-cousin marriages stand in a hierarchy, in which "sister's children" are in a subordinate position (Dupire 1970, 320–321). *Dendiraagal*, "cross-cousinship", between two distinct "lineages" can imply either alliance and a joking relationship, or a competitive opposition between the groups. Two primary lineages that have intermarried in the past and are thus related through cognatic ties are "brothers" and "sister's children", or "men" and "women" towards each other (Dupire 1962, 308–309).

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In several instances, this form of marital alliance has also served as a way of defining a hierarchy between the Wodaabe and people from other ethnic groups. Ancient marriages  8 between Wodaabe headmen and their Beriberi and Kanouri neighbors, as well as between Wodaabe and the slaves they acquired during the period of *jihad*, have remained as a basis of *dendiraagal* between Wodaabe and their ancient allies and serfs (ibid.: 27, 29, 37, 148; 1970, 225).

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